

Why It Isn't Important That Every Business Invests in AI

Artificial intelligence is now ubiquitous (Kneusel, 2023); it is built into the tools that we use every day. From online search algorithms to supermarket logistics, AI is woven into almost everything we do. However, it is not essential that all businesses actively invest in AI.

If we assume that “investment in AI” means the business owner or staff actively invest their time in training or active use of AI, then it can be argued that investment is not important for the success of all businesses.

Consider an independent restaurant. Its USP is that it is a small, local, family-run business that makes everything by hand.

If the business invests in AI, in the near future, a robot could theoretically cook the food. A general model could decorate the restaurant. An LLM could create the copy for the website and generate advertising content. But the benefit of AI in this use case is debatable. Whilst AI may save time, or even wages, the use of AI could have a negative impact on the brand. Kirk and Givi (2025) note that when consumers believe a brand to be using AI for marketing, it creates distrust and even disgust.

For an artisanal business, imperfection, such as handwritten notes with spelling or grammar mistakes, a wonky cake, or a sitting area with mismatched furniture, can conversely, add brand value (Frizzo et al., 2020).

That being said, there are an ever-rising number of instances where passive AI usage will still affect the success of the business, that the owner and staff may even be unaware of (Moravec et al., 2024). AI may run a targeted online advertising campaign (Google, no date), or be used by the customers to research a local restaurant. AI may also be used as a coding agent by the developer hired to create the company website, or be utilised by food delivery services for data management and efficiency (Cheng and Azadeh, 2025). Even the farms and distribution centres from which the restaurant buys its produce are increasingly more likely to utilise AI for logistics (Kumari et al., 2025).

In a world where everything is increasingly created and driven by AI. Not actively investing time and money in AI and instead focusing on quality and authenticity could prove to be an advantage for some businesses. However, even if a business does not actively invest in AI, AI will still have an impact on the success of a business.

This leads to the following questions: In a world of increasingly AI-driven data and content, will AI dilute the authenticity of the independent trader? Will authenticity lose its value? Will artisanal businesses survive?

References

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